

Captain Melvin's Catch

Captain Melvin checked the **anchor** to his boat, scratched his white beard and looked out at the sea. He had been fishing for hours and had nearly **given up in disgust**. A seagull flew overhead **squawking** its laughter.

"No bite, no bite," it seemed to say.

"Push off. You've not caught anything either," shouted the Captain, shaking a **fist**.

The sea gently rose and fell in big long waves. The weather was hot and still. Captain Melvin started to feel sleepy.

Then something made him look up, **shading** his eyes against sunlight flashing off the water.

"What's that?" he **muttered**.

A small straight stick **poked up** out of the sea. It seemed to be moving towards him.

"Well I'll be..." his words **trailed off** as he jumped to his feet and **peered** over the side of the boat.

The small straight stick peered back, blinking big brown eyes. Its body was as long as his arm, its back blue as the sky in summer.

Captain Melvin had to catch it.

Beside him **lay** a landing net and a bucket tied by a long rope to the **mast**. He quietly picked up the net. The creature was still there near the boat watching him.

Gently, gently the Captain moved the net towards the creature, then he **pounced**.

"Gotcha."

Putting the net on **deck**, he threw the bucket over the side and pulled it up full of water. He **shook** the creature **out** of the net and into the bucket.

The creature was like an eel, long and thin but with two pairs of tiny paddles, its long neck **sticking out** of the water looking about.

"Flip me, it's a sea **serpent**! I've caught me a sea serpent."

Captain Melvin put the bucket in the shade on the deck and went for his dinner. He sat in the deckhouse reading his paper and drinking a cup of tea. The sun was getting low in the sky, just time for another look at his prize.



The sea serpent looked back. It was swimming more slowly than before, round and round, **squashed** into the bucket.

That night the Captain couldn't sleep for excitement. In the morning he'd take the sea serpent to the local museum, maybe the British Museum.

They might even call it after him:

'Melvin's Sea Serpent (*Melvin serpentiansis*)'.

He could see it now, **stuffed** in a **glass case** for all to **admire**.

Stuffed in a glass case?

He was getting **drowsy**, but he kept seeing those big brown eyes looking out of the bucket.

Stuffed in a glass case.

Was that right?

Stuffed in a glass case...

The boat **lurched**; there was a great splash nearby.

"Whassat?" Captain Melvin jumped out of his **bunk**, grabbed a torch and went on deck.

He shone the light out over the water — nothing but a seagull bouncing on big waves.

"Squawk," said the seagull.

"Push off," said Captain Melvin and went back to his bunk.

But he couldn't sleep.

Stuffed in a case... and those eyes — brown and sad and tearful.

At last it got light and, **bleary-eyed** and with a headache, Captain Melvin poked his head out of the deckhouse and looked around. The sun shone through red morning clouds.

"Red sky in morning, sailor's warning," said Captain Melvin.

He climbed onto deck and went to look at his catch.

The little sea serpent **lay on its side**, its neck drooped over the rim of the bucket.

"Oh no, I've killed it. It's all my fault."

He poked it with a finger.

The sea serpent raised its neck and looked at him sadly, then it **drooped** again.



The Captain felt tears **pricking** his eyes.

The little sea serpent would never be stuffed in a glass case. Never.

“Come on little 'un, off you go.”

He lowered the bucket gently into the sea.

The little sea serpent **floated** out of the bucket and began to sink. Then, feeling the cool salt water, it raised its head and began swimming strongly away from the boat.



All at once, not far away, there was a **mighty splash** — a huge neck, thick as a telegraph pole, rose out of the sea and two big brown eyes **looked down on** Captain Melvin.

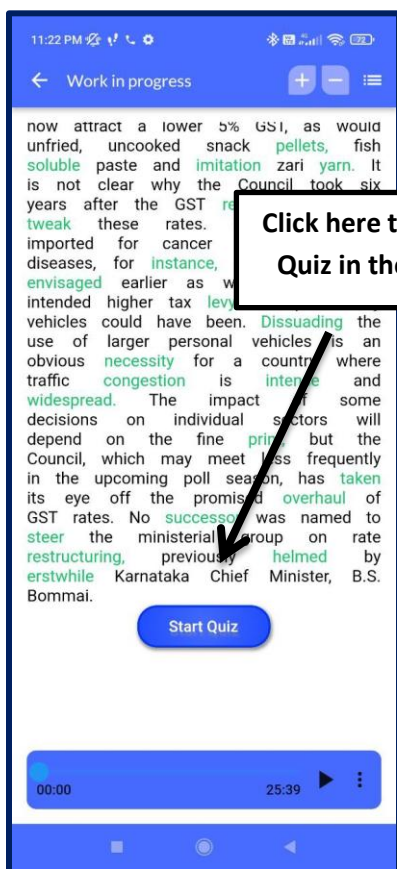
Then together, the big sea serpent and the littlest sea serpent of all **swam off** towards the red morning sun.

Vocabulary

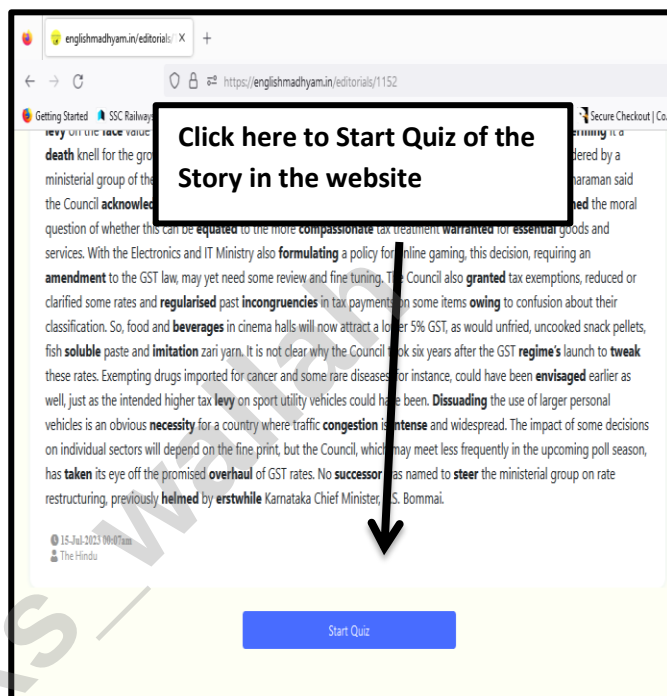
1. **Anchor** (noun) – mooring, hook, weight, hold, fastener लंकर
2. **Give up** (phrasal verb) – surrender, quit, abandon, stop, forfeit हार मान लेना
3. **In disgust** (phrase) – with revulsion, in distaste, in disapproval, angrily, with contempt – घृणा में / नफरत से
4. **Squawk** (verb) – screech, squeal, shriek, cry, screech – चिल्लाना (पक्षियों का तीखा स्वर)
5. **Fist** (noun) – clenched hand, punch, knuckle, hand, grip – मुट्ठी
6. **Shade** (verb) – block, shield, cover, screen, shadow – छाया करना / रोशनी से बचाना
7. **Mutter** (verb) – murmur, whisper, grumble, mumble, speak under breath – बड़बड़ाना
8. **Poke up** (phrasal verb) – stick out, rise up, protrude, emerge, jut – ऊपर निकल आना
9. **Trail off** (phrasal verb) – fade, taper, weaken, dwindle, fizzle – धीमा हो जाना / मंद पड़ जाना
10. **Peer** (verb) – look closely, gaze, squint, scrutinize, examine – ध्यान से देखना
11. **Lay** (verb) – place, put, position, set, rest – रखना
12. **Mast** (noun) – pole, spar, tower, upright, support – मस्तूल (जहाज का खंभा)
13. **Pounce** (verb) – jump, leap, lunge, spring, attack – झपटना / अचानक हमला करना
14. **Deck** (noun) – platform, floor, surface, board, terrace – जहाज का फर्श / डेक
15. **Shook out** (phrasal verb) – emptied, dropped, spilled, scattered, released – झाड़कर बाहर निकालना
16. **Stick out** (phrasal verb) – protrude, jut, extend, emerge, project – बाहर निकला हुआ होना
17. **Serpent** (noun) – snake, sea monster, reptile, creature, viper – साँप / सर्प
18. **Squash** (verb) – crush, squeeze, flatten, compress, press – दबाना / कुचलना
19. **Stuff** (verb) – fill, pack, cram, preserve, jam – भर देना / ठूसना / संरक्षित करना (टैक्सीडर्मी)
20. **Glass case** (noun) – display box, showcase, cabinet, enclosure, container – काँच का शोकेस / प्रदर्शनी बॉक्स
21. **Admire** (verb) – appreciate, respect, praise, marvel at, look up to – प्रशंसा करना
22. **Drowsy** (adjective) – sleepy, tired, sluggish, lethargic, dozy – नींद से भरा हुआ

23. **Lurch** (verb) – sway, stagger, roll, jerk, wobble – झटका देना / झूलना
24. **Bunk** (noun) – bed, berth, cot, sleeping place, cabin bed – जहाज/रेल का बिस्तर
25. **Bleary-eyed** (adjective) – tired-eyed, foggy-eyed, blurry-eyed, groggy, half-awake – थकी हुई आँखों वाला
26. **Lay on one's side** (phrase) – recline sideways, rest laterally, lie tilted, lie slanted, sprawl – करवट में लेटना
27. **Droop** (verb) – sag, wilt, sink, fall, slump – झुकना / लटकना
28. **Prick** (verb) – sting, poke, pierce, tingle, jab – चुभन होना / चुभाना
29. **Float** (verb) – drift, hover, glide, sail, bob – तैरना
30. **Mighty** (adjective) – powerful, great, enormous, huge, strong – शक्तिशाली / बहुत बड़ा
31. **Splash** (noun) – spatter, spray, plop, plash, slosh – छपाक / छींटा
32. **Look down on** (phrase) – disdain, scorn, belittle, mock, regard with contempt – तिरस्कार से देखना
33. **Swam off** (phrasal verb) – departed, floated away, glided off, paddled off, drifted away – तैरते हुए दूर चले जाना

Practice Exercise



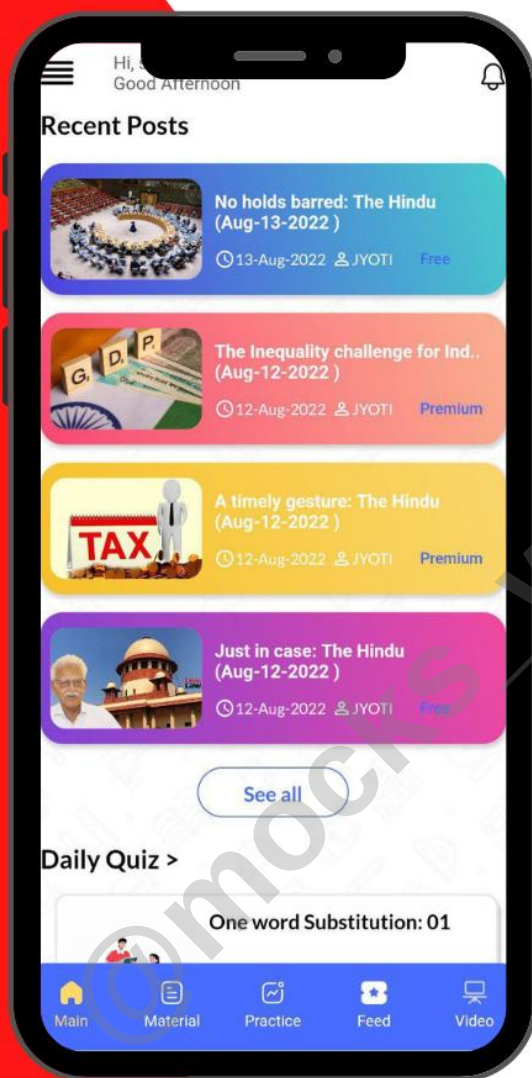
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